

INDIAN MUSEUM, KOLKATA

HAUNT OF HISTORY

VALUABLE ENSEMBLE

The collection at the museum is particularly rich in paintings depicting primarily portraits, book illustrations and varied scenes of the Mughal era.

PRESERVED IN TIME

The earliest painting at the museum is an illustrated palm-leaf manuscript dating back to the Pala dynasty in late 12th century.

The pillars of the great white mansion whisper the saga of the glorious past they have once seen. History breathes within its four walls, the cacophony of the modern-day world cannot escape the ever watchful eyes of the statues that are placed like sentinels at its doorstep. Welcome to the world of the Indian Museum, one of the greatest institutions that signifies the rich cultural and historical identity of India.

Established on February 2, 1814, in Serampore by Danish botanist Nathaniel Wallich, the museum started off as a part of the Asiatic Society. Known as the Asiatic Museum and subsequently as the Imperial Museum in its formative phases, it was transferred to the present building at Saddar Street in central Kolkata in 1878. Starting with two sections initially—archaeology, ethnology and technology, and the other geology and zoology—the museum

now has six sections and 60 galleries. Under the cultural wing of the West Bengal Government, it spreads over 8,000 sq m and is now an autonomous body run by a board of trustees. The centre of attraction is undoubtedly the mummy of a servant of an Egyptian pharaoh, the only one in India. "The authorities faced a lot of trouble while transporting the mummy from Egypt in 1884, leading them to believe the mummy was cursed. There are many who still believe the museum is haunted," says museum Director Anuradha Mukherjee. The museum has other prized possessions as well such as the grail of Mughal emperor Shahjahan and a terracotta slab of the 3rd century which still bears the signature of the great Ashoka. All set to celebrate its bi-centenary in 2014, the Indian Museum, despite recent irregularities, will continue to hold a special place in the heart of the nation. **by Manisha Dasgupta**

PRECIOUS DEPOSIT: The mummy of a servant of an Egyptian pharaoh



SUBIR HALDER